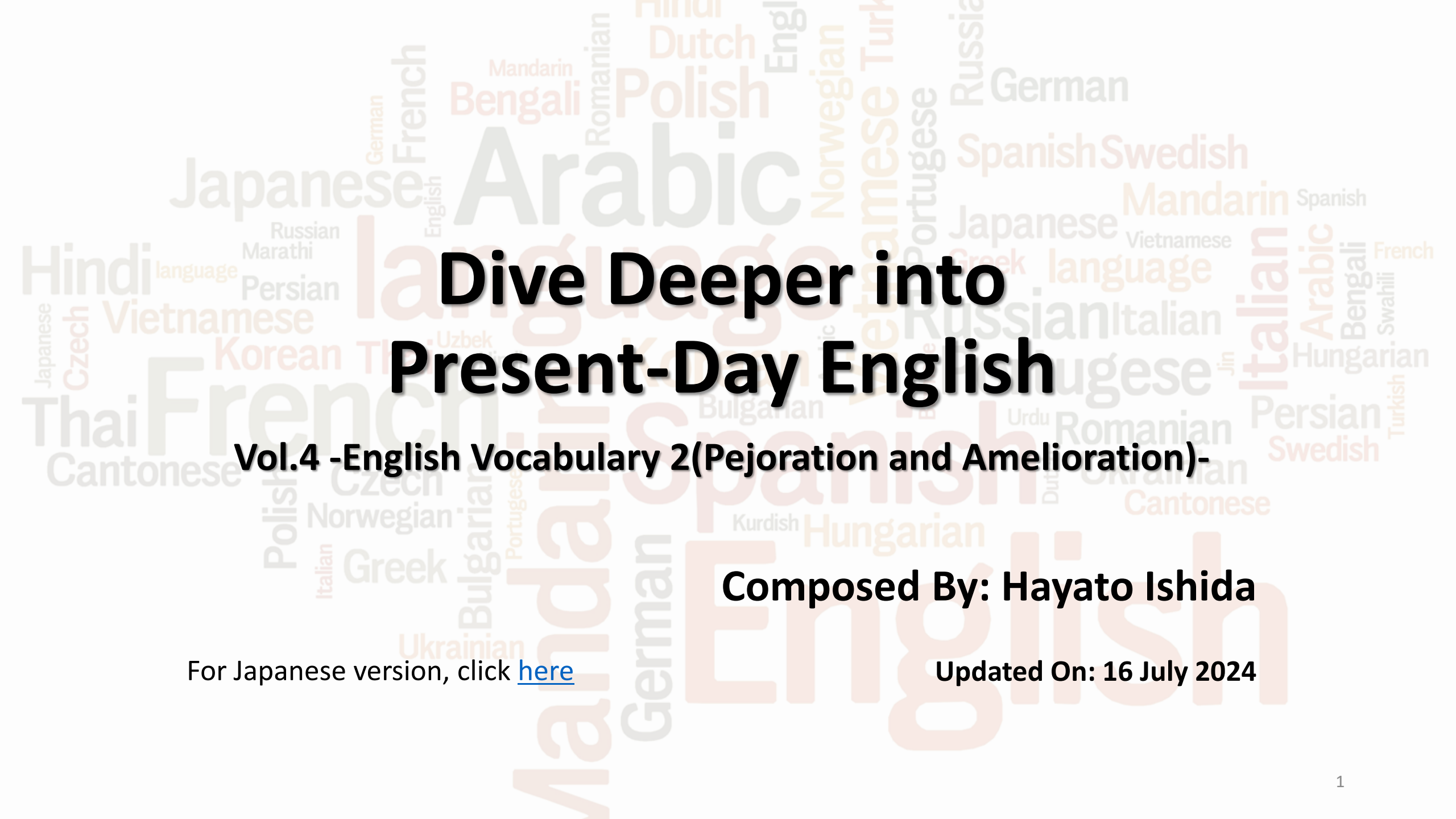




Dive Deeper into Present-Day English

Vol.4 -English Vocabulary 2(Pejoration and Amelioration)-

Composed By: Hayato Ishida

For Japanese version, click [here](#)

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About Me

- Accounts
 - GitHub: [@hayat01sh1da](#)
 - X: [@hayat01sh1da](#)
 - LinkedIn: [@hayat01sh1da](#)
 - Speaker Deck: [@hayat01sh1da](#)
 - Docswell: [@hayat01sh1da](#)
- Occupation: Software Engineer
- Things I Am Into
 - Linguistics
 - Singing at Karaoke
 - Listening to Music
 - Watching Movies
 - Cat Feeding



Licences / Certifications

- English
 - TOEIC® Listening & Reading 915: Certified on December 2019
- Engineering
 - Information Security Management: Certified on November 2017
 - Applied Information Technology Engineer: Certified on June 2017
 - Fundamental Information Technology Engineer: Certified on November 2016
 - IT Passport: Certified on April 2016
- Others
 - Abacus 2nd Class: Certified on June 2002
 - Mental Arithmetic 3rd Class: Certified on February 2001

Skill Stack

- Languages
 - Japanese: Native Proficiency
 - English: Full professional Proficiency
- Development
 - **Backend:** Ruby(Ruby on Rails), Python
 - Frontend: TypeScript + React.js, TypeScript +Vue.js
 - **Database:** MySQL, PostgreSQL, MongoDB
 - **Architecture:** Monolith, Modular Monolith
 - Hosting: AWS ESK
 - Versioning: Git, GitHub
 - **CI/CD:** GitHub Actions, ArgoCD
 - Monitoring: Datadog, Sentry

Work Histories

Period	Genre	Position	Jobs
Aug 2021 - Present	SaaS(Educational Service)	Software Engineer	• Backend Development • Frontend Development • CI/CD Maintenance • Weekly Release Manager • Troubleshooting • Documentation • Technical Debt Resolution • Tech Blog Entries • LT Speaker
Feb 2020 - Dec 2020	SaaS(Chatbot Platform)	Backend Engineer	• Backend Development • Documentation • Technical Debt Resolution • Inspection of Alternative API

Work Histories

Period	Genre	Position	Jobs
Jun 2018 - Jan 2020	Contract-basis Developer	Software Engineer	• Backend Development • Frontend Development • Troubleshooting • Quality Assurance • Tech Blog Entries
Apr 2016 - Jan 2018	System Engineering Service	System Engineer	• Corporate Account Admin • Windows Server Maintenance • Security Admin Assistant • Internationalisation / Localisation

International-Exchange Activities

- Activities in University
 - English Linguistics Seminar(Focusing on Mass Media English)
 - International-Exchange Clubs(The 2nd Year)
 - [International-Exchange Programmes conducted by Japan Cabinet Office](#)(2013 - 2016)
 - Japanese Linguistics Course(The Final Year)
- Overseas Life Experience
 - Working Holiday in Australia(April 2014 - March 2015)
 - Language School for 1 month in Sydney
 - Work for 6 Months in [Hamilton Island Resort](#)
 - Volunteering for 1 Month as Assistant Teacher of Japanese Language at [St Ives High School](#) in NSW
- Other Activities
 - Keep Everyday Journal in English (April 2014 - Present)
 - [Sunrise Toastmasters Club](#)(February 2017 - March 2018)
 - [Vital Japan](#)(January 2018 - July 2019, October 2022 - February 2023)
 - Self Learning and Training of English Language
 - Participation Ruby-Related Tech Conferences

Goals of This Series

- **To know how deep English Language is**
 - Not simply a communication tool
- **To know your own language by knowing another**
 - "He who knows no foreign languages knows nothing of his own." by Johann Wolfgang von Goethe
- **To pursue the essence that does not instantly but work later on**
 - Something which you think is meaningless has something genuine

Agenda

1. [Pejoration](#)
2. [Amelioration](#)
3. [Summary](#)
4. [References](#)

1. Pejoration

English language has some words that are used as bad meanings which used to originally as good ones in its vocabulary.

Linguistic change from a good meaning to bad one through a long English history is called **Pejoration**.

[silly](#) represents it according to [Dictionary.com](#), so why do we not discuss the historical changes of its forms and meanings?

1. Pejoration

- **Some Definitions of *silly* on [Dictionary.com](https://www.dictionary.com)**

- weak-minded or lacking good sense; stupid or foolish
- absurd; ridiculous; irrational
- [Archaic] rustic; plain; homely
- [Archaic] weak; helpless
- [Obsolete] lowly in rank or state; humble

- **Historical Changes of Word Forms of *silly***

- Old English: *gesælig* as 'happy' and 'blessed'
 - The prefix *-ge* dropped and the suffix *-ig* became *-ly* observed all over English today as in *juicy* and *dreamy* etc.
 - *sæl* meant 'happiness'
- Early Middle English: *sylie*, *sillie*
- Late Middle English: *syly*, variant of *sely* [*seely*](#)

1. Pejoration

Historical Changes in Word Meanings of *silly*

Periods	Meanings
Old English	<i>happy, blessed</i>
Early Middle English	<i>holy, innocent, helpless</i>
Mid Middle English	<i>pitiable, insignificant; simple, ignorant</i>
Late Middle English	<i>lacking in good sense, foolish, irrational, ridiculous</i>

1. Pejoration

Historical Changes in Word Meanings of *silly* in Depth

Something **happy** can be considered ***favoured by God***.

Something ***favoured by God*** can be considered **holy**, and so **innocent**, which may be said of a small animal or child who is **harmless** or **defenseless**.

And if you cannot protect yourself or you lack power, you might be considered **worthless** or **miserable** - and so silly apparently jumps to **foolish**.

Reference: [Dictionary.com](https://www.dictionary.com) > [Silly](#) > [MORE ABOUT SILLY](#) > Dig Deeper

1. Pejoration

The Difference in Terms of Nuances compared with A Synonym

The precedent historical changes of word meanings makes a difference in terms of nuance, which leads to distinctions between synonyms.

- *A friend of mine often tells me, "You are stupid".*
 - The friend of yours likely to strongly declare that you are really foolish.
- *A friend of mine often tells me, "You are silly".*
 - The friend of yours feels like you are foolish with senses of pity and empathy to you.

1. Pejoration

Other Examples of Pejoration

Words	Origins	Present Meanings
<u>knave</u>	• Old English: <i>cnafa</i> • Middle English: First recorded before 1000 • Cognate with <i>Knabe</i>('boy') and akin to <i>knapi</i>('page', 'boy') in Old Norse	an unprincipled, untrustworthy, or dishonest person.
<u>villain</u>	• First recorded 1275 - 1325 • Middle English: <i>vilein</i> • Middle French: <i>villain</i>('churlish rustic', 'serf') • Vulgar Latin and Medieval Latin: <i>villānus</i>('a farm servant', 'farmhand')	a cruelly malicious person
<u>cunning</u>	• Old English: <i>cunnung</i> • Middle English: First recorded in 1275 - 1325 as noun	skill employed in a shrewd or sly manner

2. Amelioration

English language has some words that are used as bad meanings which used to originally as good ones in its vocabulary.

Linguistic change from a good meaning to bad one through a long English history is called **Amelioration**.

[nice](#) represents it according to [Dictionary.com](#), so why do we not discuss the historical changes of its forms and meanings?

2. Amelioration

- Some Definitions of *nice* on [Dictionary.com](https://www.dictionary.com)

- pleasing; agreeable; delightful
- amiably pleasant; kind
- [Obsolete] coy, shy, or reluctant
- [Obsolete] unimportant; trivial
- [Obsolete] wanton

- Historical Changes of Word Forms of *nice*

- *nescius* in Latin
 - Consists of a negative prefix *ne-* + *sci-* (stem of *scīre* meaning 'to know') + an adjective suffix *-us*

2. Amelioration

Historical Changes in Word Meanings of *nice*

- First recorded in 1250 - 1300 in Middle English meaning 'foolish' and 'stupid'
- *silly* and *simple* from French
- *ignorant* and *incapable* from Latin
- The transition below follows later on
 - *wanton*
 - *fastidious, fussy*
 - *difficult to manage*
 - *minute and subtle*
 - *precise, critical*
 - *minutely accurately*
 - *pleasant, attractive*

2. Amelioration

Historical Changes in Word Meanings of *nice* in Depth

Originally it referred to something *foolish* and *stupid* and then it came to mention something *reckless*.

Such things are *difficult to manage*, but they require someone to be *sensitive* and deal with things in a *minutely accurate* way.

It has changed into the present meaning *pleasant* and *attractive*.

2. Amelioration

Polysemy in the 16 - 17th Century during the Transition of Meanings

The same writer expressed something totally different with the same word.

- *nice and trivial*
 - *Richard 3*, Act 3, Scene 7, Line 175, William Shakespeare
- *on the nice hazard of one doubtful hour*
 - *Henry 3*, 4, Part 1, Act 4, Scene 1, Line 48, William Shakespeare

2. Amelioration

Other Examples of Amelioration

Words	Origins	Present Meanings
boy	- Old English: A man's name <i>Bōia</i> - Middle English: <i>boy(e)</i> - First recorded 1250 - 1300 - Cognate with Frisian <i>boi</i> 'young man' - Akin to Old English <i>bōfa</i>, Old Norse <i>bōfi</i>, Old High German <i>Buobo</i> a man's name (German <i>Bube</i> 'knave' - dialectal 'boy', 'lad')	a male child, from birth to full growth
fame	1175 - 1225 - Roots: Middle English < Anglo-French, Old French < Latin <i>fāma</i> of which meanings were talk, public opinion, repute; akin to <i>fārī</i> (to speak)	widespread reputation
pretty	- Old English: <i>prættig</i>, <i>prettī</i> 'cunning', derivative of <i>prætt</i> 'trick', 'wile' - Middle English: <i>prati(e)</i>, <i>pratte</i>, <i>prettie</i> meaning 'cunning', 'gallant', 'fine', 'handsome', pretty' - First recorded before 1000 - Cognate with Dutch <i>part</i>, <i>pret</i> 'trick', 'prank' and Old Norse <i>prettr</i> 'trick', <i>prettugr</i> 'tricky'	pleasing or attractive to the eye, as by delicacy or gracefulness

3. Summary

1. **Pejoration** is the historical changes of words from **Good** to **Bad** meanings.
2. **Amelioration** is the historical changes of words from **Bad** to **Good** meanings.
3. Survival of vocabulary requires words to have distinct meanings or nuances from those of synonyms.
4. To dig deeper the history of a word, you will find the answer.

4. References

- Kiyoaki Kikuchi • Kazutomo Karasawa • Takeshi Koike • Ryuichi Hotta • Kazuki Fukuda • Yasuyuki Kaizuka • Takeshi Matsuzaki, 英語学：現代英語をより深く知るために-現代英語の諸相と英語学術語解説-, *Osaka*, 浪漫書房, 2008
- [Dictionary.com](https://www.dictionary.com)
 - Last Accessed On: 11 February 2024

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